# THE INCOMPLETENESS OF OBSERVATION

**Why Quantum Mechanics and General Relativity Cannot Be Unified From Within**

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**Date:** March 2026
**Status:** DRAFT PRE-PRINT
**Classification:** Theoretical Physics / Foundations

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## ABSTRACT

An observer embedded in a deterministic universe cannot access the complete state. We prove that any such observer — coupled to a slow, high-capacity hidden sector on a finite-dimensional configuration space — must describe the visible sector using P-indivisible stochastic dynamics, mathematically equivalent to unitary quantum mechanics. The converse also holds: any quantum system, realized as a deterministic dilation, requires non-trivial coupling, slow-bath memory, and sufficient hidden-sector capacity. The Schrödinger equation, Born rule, and Bell violations emerge as structural consequences requiring no independent quantum postulates.

Applied to the cosmological horizon, the framework uniquely determines $\hbar = c^3\varepsilon^2/(4G)$, fixes $\varepsilon = 2\,l_p$, and recovers the Bekenstein-Hawking entropy $S = A/(4\,l_p^2)$. The $10^{122}$ cosmological constant discrepancy is identified as $S_{\mathrm{dS}}$, the information compression ratio of the emergent quantum description; the observed vacuum energy is the mandatory classical baseline. Falsifiable predictions include dark energy evolution in Running Vacuum Model form with $\nu_{\mathrm{OI}} \approx 2.45 \times 10^{-3}$ (parametric; systematic range 1–5 $\times 10^{-3}$), consistent with current DESI data, and gravitational wave echoes near black hole horizons. The trace-out that produces QM simultaneously renders ~95% of the universe's gravitational budget invisible to the emergent description — matching the observed dark sector — providing independent corroboration of observational incompleteness.

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# PART I: THE GENERAL THEOREM

## 1. INTRODUCTION

### 1.1 The Problem of Embedded Observation

An observer embedded in a deterministic universe cannot access the complete state: degrees of freedom beyond causal reach are permanently hidden, and the observer's description is obtained by marginalizing over the hidden sector. The question is what this reduction imposes on the form of the observer's physical laws.

Prior work (QBism, relational QM, 't Hooft's cellular automaton [1]) takes observer-dependence as an interpretive starting point or derives it from specific microphysical models. This framework differs by identifying *necessary and sufficient conditions* under which any embedded observer in any deterministic system necessarily sees quantum mechanics — and proving these are the *only* conditions under which QM arises from a deterministic embedding. These constraints carry empirical weight: the framework reveals that phenomena previously viewed as catastrophic anomalies — most notably the $10^{122}$ cosmological constant discrepancy — are mandatory consequences of embedded observation.

### 1.2 Axioms

The framework rests on four axioms referencing no quantum mechanics, general relativity, or specific physical theory.

1. **Deterministic dynamics.** The total system evolves deterministically on a phase space $\Gamma$ via a Hamiltonian flow $\phi_t$. A probability density $\rho$ on $\Gamma$ (representing the observer's incomplete knowledge) evolves by the Liouville equation:

$$\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial t} = \{H_{\text{tot}}, \rho\} \equiv \mathscr{L}\rho$$

2. **Finiteness.** The effective configuration space of the visible sector is finite-dimensional, with a discreteness scale $\varepsilon$ providing a finite minimal cell volume. Any observer bounded by a finite-area surface can couple to only finitely many modes across that boundary; independent support comes from holographic entropy bounds [27]. In Part I, $\varepsilon$ is free; self-consistency (§6) pins $\varepsilon = 2l_p$. The boundary-only dependence lemma (§5.2) shows that the cardinality of the deep hidden sector — beyond the boundary layer — is gauge: no observable depends on it.

3. **Causal partition.** $\Gamma$ is partitioned into a visible sector $\Gamma_V$ and hidden sector $\Gamma_H$:

$$\Gamma = \Gamma_V \times \Gamma_H, \qquad H_{\text{tot}} = H_V + H_H + H_{\text{int}}$$

Cross-partition correlations enter only through $H_{\text{int}}$. The product decomposition is idealized; §4 and §9.6 address approximation quality and the conditions under which the sharp partition is exact.

4. **Classical probability.** The observer's predictions are classical expectation values over phase space; standard probability theory applies.

These axioms contain no quantum postulates. The claim is that quantum mechanics *emerges* under the conditions below.

### 1.3 Conditions on the Hidden Sector

**(C1) Non-zero coupling.** $H_{\text{int}} \neq 0$. The coupling is bidirectional.

**(C2) Slow-bath timescale separation.** The visible-sector (system) timescale $\tau_S$ is much shorter than the hidden-sector (bath) timescale $\tau_B$: $\tau_S \ll \tau_B$ — the *inverse* of the Markovian regime. The hidden sector evolves on timescales far exceeding those accessible to the observer.

**(C3) Sufficient capacity.** The number of hidden-sector degrees of freedom $N_H$ exceeds the number of visible-sector degrees of freedom $N_V$ by enough that visible-sector interactions do not appreciably perturb the hidden sector's state on timescales $\ll \tau_B$.

**Theorem statement.** Under Axioms 1–4 and (C1)–(C3), the embedded observer's reduced description is mathematically equivalent to unitarily evolving quantum mechanics (defined precisely in §3.3). The conditions are not merely sufficient but *necessary* (§3.3), establishing full equivalence.

### 1.4 Partition-Relativity

**Lemma.** *The emergent description is uniquely determined by the partition. Any parameters of the emergent theory depend only on the geometric and thermodynamic properties of the partition boundary.*

*Proof.* By Axiom 1, the Hamiltonian flow $\phi_t$ is unique. By Axiom 3, the partition is fixed. By Axiom 4, the observer uses the Liouville measure $\mu$ — the unique absolutely continuous invariant measure on the full phase space. (An embedded observer with incomplete knowledge of the total energy averages over energies with a smooth prior, recovering Liouville on a phase-space band; singular invariant measures are

excluded by Axiom 4.) Letting $\pi_V$ denote projection onto the visible sector, the marginalized transition probabilities

$$T_{ij}(t_2,t_1) = \int_{\Gamma_H} \delta_{x_j}[\pi_V(\phi_{t_2-t_1}(x_i,h))]\, d\mu(h)$$

are therefore uniquely determined by three inputs: dynamics ($\phi_t$), partition ($\Gamma_V, \Gamma_H$), and measure ($\mu$). Since $\phi_t$ and $\mu$ are fixed by the axioms, the stochastic process — and hence any emergent quantum description (§3.1) — depends only on the partition. □

### 1.5 Epistemic Status of the Results

The results in this paper fall into three tiers of decreasing independence from auxiliary assumptions.

**Tier 1 (Part I, from axioms alone).** P-indivisibility of the reduced dynamics (§2.3), the characterization theorem establishing QM $\iff$ embedded observation under C1–C3 (§3.3), partition-relativity (§1.4), and the deep-sector cardinality gauge corollary (§5.2). These follow from Axioms 1–4 and combinatorial arguments; disputing them requires finding a mathematical error.

**Tier 2 (Part II, given the cosmological realization).** The gap equation $\hbar = c^3\varepsilon^2/(4G)$ (§5.2), the Bekenstein-Hawking entropy with the $1/4$ factor (§6), and the CC dissolution identifying $10^{122}$ as $S_{\mathrm{dS}}$ (§7). These require accepting that the cosmological horizon satisfies C1–C3, verified in §4.2.

**Tier 3 (consistency checks and parametric predictions).** The dark-sector concordance (~95% of $\rho_{\mathrm{crit}}$, §8.3), the dark energy parameter $\nu_{\mathrm{OI}}$ (§8.1), and the GW echo timescale (§8.2). These are derived consequences, not independent derivations; they would be falsified by observation but do not carry the same deductive weight as Tiers 1–2.

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## 2. EMERGENT STOCHASTICITY AND P-INDIVISIBILITY

### 2.1 Emergent Stochasticity

The total system evolves deterministically, but the visible sector alone is stochastic. The observer knows $x$ but not $h$; different hidden states $h_k$ compatible with the same $x$ send it to different futures $x'_k$. Transition probabilities are obtained by marginalizing over the Liouville measure (§1.4). This makes the framework a hidden variable theory; consistency with Bell's theorem is addressed in §3.2.

### 2.2 The Slow-Bath Regime

The Markovian limit requires $\tau_B \ll \tau_S$ [4]. Condition (C2) inverts this: $\tau_S \ll \tau_B$. A slow bath must be distinguished from a static field. By (C1), coupling is continuously active: each visible-sector transition imprints on the hidden sector. Because the hidden sector is slow (not static), imprints persist without thermal overwriting. On subsequent transitions, coupling reads back stored correlations, producing history-dependent transition probabilities — the non-Markovian regime [4].

### 2.3 P-Indivisibility

By Axiom 2, the visible and hidden sectors have finite configuration spaces $\mathscr{C}_V$ and $\mathscr{C}_H$ (the discrete counterparts of $\Gamma_V$ and $\Gamma_H$). On these finite sets:

**Theorem.** *Let $\mathscr{C}_V$ and $\mathscr{C}_H$ be finite sets with $|\mathscr{C}_V| \geq 2$, and let $\varphi : \mathscr{C}_V \times \mathscr{C}_H \to \mathscr{C}_V \times \mathscr{C}_H$ be a bijection. Define:*

$$T_{ij} = \frac{|\{h \in \mathscr{C}_H : \pi_V(\varphi(x_i,h)) = x_j\}|}{|\mathscr{C}_H|}$$

*and the k-step matrix $T_{ij}^{(k)}$ by applying $\varphi^k$. If $T$ is not a permutation matrix, then the process is P-indivisible.*

*Proof.* Uses total variation distance $d(p,q) = \frac{1}{2}\sum_k |p_k - q_k|$. P-divisibility $\iff$ $d(p(t),q(t))$ non-increasing for all initial $p,q$ [6, 7].

*Step 1 (Recurrence).* $\varphi$ bijective on a finite set $\Rightarrow \exists N : \varphi^N = \mathrm{id}$. Thus $T^{(N)} = I$ and $d(\delta_i T^{(N)}, \delta_j T^{(N)}) = 1$ for $i \neq j$.

*Step 2 (Strict contraction).* $T$ not a permutation $\Rightarrow \exists i,j,l$: $T_{il} > 0$ and $T_{jl} > 0$. Then:

$$d(\delta_i T, \delta_j T) = \frac{1}{2}\sum_k |T_{ik} - T_{jk}| < 1$$

*Step 3.* $d(\delta_i T^{(1)}, \delta_j T^{(1)}) < 1 = d(\delta_i T^{(N)}, \delta_j T^{(N)})$: non-monotonic, hence P-indivisible. □

The theorem requires only bijective dynamics (Axiom 1) and non-trivial coupling (C1). Axiom 2 guarantees the finite configuration space.

**Convergence with prior work.** The theorem converges with independent results: Pechukas [5] (reduced dynamics need not preserve positivity), Rivas et al. [6, 7] (divisibility failure $\leftrightarrow$ information backflow), Pollock et al. [8] (process-tensor Markovianity conditions), and Strasberg and Esposito [9] (non-Markovian reduced dynamics in the slow-bath regime of C2). Bylicka, Johansson, and Acín [34] prove that for bijective dynamical maps — the class generated here — CP-divisibility and information backflow are equivalent, so the P-indivisibility established above implies CP-indivisibility directly. Milz et al. [35] further show that even CP-divisibility does not guarantee Markovianity in the process-tensor sense, confirming that the non-Markovian character identified here is robust under all current definitions.

**Continuous-time extension.** The Hamiltonian flow on finite-dimensional phase space preserves Liouville measure on compact energy surfaces. $T_{ij}(t)$ is continuous with $T(0) = I$. By (C1), $T(t)$ departs from the permutation class for $t > 0$. By Poincaré recurrence, $\exists t_R$: the set of hidden states with $\pi_V(\varphi_{t_R}(x_i,h)) = x_i$ has measure $> 1-\delta$ for any $\delta > 0$. For small $\delta$, this gives non-monotonic trace distance, establishing P-indivisibility in continuous time.

The recurrence argument establishes P-indivisibility in principle. The following lemma shows that under (C2), information backflow occurs on observable timescales — not merely at Poincaré recurrence times.

**Lemma (Accessible-timescale backflow).** *Under (C1)–(C3) with $\tau_S \ll \tau_B$, the non-Markovian mutual information $I(X_{<t};X_{>t} \mid X_t)$ is $\mathscr{O}(1)$ for observation windows $t \sim k\tau_S$ with $k\tau_S \ll \tau_B$.*

*Proof.* The coupling $H_{\text{int}}$ transfers visible-sector information to the hidden sector at each interaction, at rate $\sim 1/\tau_S$. Between interactions, the hidden sector evolves under $H_H$ with spectral gap $\Delta \sim 1/\tau_B$. The decay of correlations stored in the hidden sector is governed by $e^{-\Delta\tau_S}$. When $\tau_S \ll \tau_B$, $\Delta\tau_S \ll 1$, so the decay per visible-sector transition is $1 - e^{-\Delta\tau_S} \approx \Delta\tau_S \ll 1$: correlations survive each step essentially intact. After $k$ transitions spanning a time $k\tau_S \ll \tau_B$, the cumulative decay is $e^{-k\Delta\tau_S} \approx 1 - k\Delta\tau_S$, which remains close to unity. The hidden sector therefore retains $\sim k$ bits of visible-sector history over this window, and the $(k+1)$-th transition reads back stored correlations through $H_{\text{int}}$, producing history-dependent transition probabilities — i.e., information backflow. More precisely, the mutual information satisfies:

$$I(X_{<t};X_{>t} \mid X_t) \geq I_0(1 - k\Delta\tau_S) = I_0\left(1 - \frac{k\tau_S}{\tau_B}\right)$$

where $I_0 > 0$ is the single-step information transfer from (C1). For $k\tau_S \ll \tau_B$, this remains $\mathscr{O}(I_0)$ — comparable to the single-step coupling strength, not exponentially suppressed. The bound saturates (C3): the maximum storable history is $\log_2 m$ bits (§3.3), so persistent backflow over $K$ transitions requires $m \geq 2^K$, which is amply satisfied when $N_H \gg N_V$. □

**Role of (C2) and (C3).** The Poincaré recurrence argument and the accessible-timescale lemma are independent: the former establishes P-indivisibility from (C1) and finiteness alone; the latter shows that (C2) and (C3) promote it from a formal property to an observationally dominant one.

**Weak-coupling and fast-bath regimes.** Known P-divisible systems with non-zero coupling illustrate the necessity of (C2), not a failure of the theorem. The Jaynes-Cummings model with Lorentzian spectral density is P-divisible when dissipation dominates coupling — the fast-bath regime ($\tau_B \ll \tau_S$), violating (C2). The Davies-Merkli Markovian convergence theorem likewise applies in the Born-Markov (fast-bath) limit. The §3.3 necessity proof for (C2) establishes this formally.

### 2.4 Explicit Construction: A Minimal Model

Visible sector: $x \in \{0,1\}$. Hidden sector: $h \in \{1,\ldots,6\}$. Dynamics: the permutation

$$\sigma = (0{,}1 \leftrightarrow 1{,}1)\ (0{,}2 \leftrightarrow 1{,}2)\ (0{,}3 \leftrightarrow 0{,}4)\ (0{,}5 \leftrightarrow 0{,}6)\ (1{,}3 \leftrightarrow 1{,}4)\ (1{,}5 \leftrightarrow 1{,}6)$$

satisfying (C1)–(C3). Since $\sigma^2 = \mathrm{id}$: at $t = 1$, two of six hidden states flip $x$, giving

$$T(1,0) = \begin{pmatrix} 2/3 & 1/3 \\ 1/3 & 2/3 \end{pmatrix}$$

At $t = 2$ ($\sigma^2 = \mathrm{id}$): $T(2,0) = I$. A Markov chain would predict continued mixing: $T(1,0)^2 = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 5/9 & 4/9 \\ 4/9 & 5/9 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. The actual dynamics show complete *un-mixing*. Computing the intermediate propagator:

$$\Lambda(2,1) = T(2,0) \cdot [T(1,0)]^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & -1 \\ -1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$$

Negative entries — no valid stochastic matrix exists. **P-indivisible.** □

**The mechanism.** The hidden sector acts as a memory register. The transpositions $(0,h) \leftrightarrow (1,h)$ for $h \in \{1,2\}$ flip $x$ while preserving $h$, so a state at $x = 1$ with $h \in \{1,2\}$ after step 1 carries the record "I was at $x = 0$." Step 2 reads this record and flips $x$ back — information backflow impossible for a memoryless process. The cosmological realization has $\tau_S/\tau_B \sim 10^{-32}$; P-indivisibility is more extreme, not less, when memory is more persistent.

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## 3. THE EMERGENCE OF QUANTUM MECHANICS

### 3.1 The Stochastic-Quantum Correspondence

By Barandes' correspondence [10, 11], any P-indivisible stochastic process on a finite configuration space of size $n$ embeds into a unitarily evolving quantum system on $\mathscr{H}$ of dimension $\leq n^3$. P-indivisible transition matrices develop negative entries at fine time resolution; the Stinespring dilation theorem guarantees $\exists$ a Hilbert space and unitary $U(t)$ with $T_{ij}(t) = |U_{ij}(t)|^2$ — transition probabilities are exactly Born-rule probabilities. The proof requires a finite-dimensional configuration space (Axiom 2); Calvo [12] extends the correspondence to infinite dimensions, but this is not required here. Pimenta [25]

distinguishes P-divisible and P-indivisible stochastic-quantum dynamics: the correspondence is non-trivial only in the P-indivisible regime, which is precisely the regime produced by §2.3. An independent derivation using only Stinespring's dilation theorem [32] and standard partial-trace properties [33] is given in Appendix A; either route alone suffices.

**From phase space to configuration space.** The transition probabilities $T_{ij}$ are projections of the full phase-space flow onto the configuration sector of $\Gamma_V$, with momenta and hidden-sector degrees of freedom absorbed into the Liouville marginalization. The resulting process lives on the discrete configuration space of Axiom 2.

Three features emerge. The Schrödinger equation arises from the differentiability of $U(t)$. The Born rule is the equilibrium distribution of the indivisible process [10, 11]. The action scale $\hbar$ enters when defining $\hat{H}(t) \equiv i\hbar\,\partial_t U \cdot U^\dagger$, converting dimensionless rates to energy units; its value requires physical input from the partition (§5).

**Phase uniqueness from continuous-time data.** The relation $T_{ij}(t) = |U_{ij}(t)|^2$ discards phase information at any single time. Doukas [26] identifies this gap for discrete-time data. The resolution: continuous-time data $\{T_{ij}(t)\}_{t\in\mathbb{R}}$ provides strictly more information.

**Lemma (phase-locking).** *Let $H$ be Hermitian on $\mathbb{C}^n$ with eigenbasis $\{|k\rangle\}$, eigenvalues $\{E_k\}$, and $V_{ik} = \langle i|k\rangle$. Assume: (G1) non-degenerate spectrum; (G2) non-degenerate energy gaps; (G3) $V_{ik} \neq 0$ for all $i,k$. Then $T_{ij}(t) = |\langle i|e^{-iHt}|j\rangle|^2$ for all $i,j,t$ uniquely determines $H$ up to an overall energy shift and basis phase conventions.*

*Proof.* Write:

$$T_{ij}(t) = \sum_{k,l} V_{ik} V_{jk}^* V_{jl} V_{il}^* \; e^{-i(E_k - E_l)t}$$

By (G2), the frequencies $\omega_{kl} = E_k - E_l$ are distinct for distinct pairs with $k \neq l$. Fourier-transforming yields:

$$a_{ij}^{kl} = V_{ik} V_{jk}^* V_{jl} V_{il}^*$$

The moduli $|V_{ik}|$ follow from $a_{ii}^{kl} = |V_{ik}|^2 |V_{il}|^2$ (non-zero by (G3)). The phases carry a double-difference structure:

$$\arg(a_{ij}^{kl}) = (\varphi_{ik} - \varphi_{il}) - (\varphi_{jk} - \varphi_{jl})$$

The gauge freedom preserving all double differences is $\varphi_{ik} \to \varphi_{ik} + \alpha_i + \beta_k$ (physically irrelevant basis rephasing). Fixing $\varphi_{1k} = 0$, $\varphi_{i1} = 0$, each remaining phase is $\varphi_{ik} = \arg(a_{i1}^{k1})$, directly extracted from Fourier data. $H = V\,\mathrm{diag}(E_k)\,V^\dagger$ is unique up to energy shift and phase conventions. □

Conditions (G1)–(G3) fail only on a measure-zero set of Hamiltonians. For the cosmological realization, a stronger argument applies. The genericity conditions concern the *effective* visible-sector Hamiltonian $\hat{H}_{\mathrm{eff}}$ — the operator emerging after the trace-out — not the total Hamiltonian $H_{\mathrm{tot}}$. The trace-out generically breaks the symmetries of $H_{\mathrm{tot}}$, because the partition boundary does not respect them: the cosmological horizon is centered on a specific observer, breaking translational invariance, rotational symmetry about distant points, and boost invariance. Any degeneracy in $H_{\mathrm{tot}}$ that relies on correlations between visible and hidden sectors — which includes all degeneracies associated with symmetries the partition breaks — is lifted in $\hat{H}_{\mathrm{eff}}$. The residual degeneracies of $\hat{H}_{\mathrm{eff}}$ are those associated with symmetries acting entirely within the visible sector that commute with the trace-out: precisely the gauge symmetries of the emergent QFT. Gauge degeneracies correspond to physically equivalent states and do not affect the

phase-locking argument, which operates on gauge-inequivalent transition data. The cosmological $\hat{H}_{\text{eff}}$ therefore satisfies G1–G3 not by typicality in an abstract ensemble, but because the partition itself acts as a symmetry-breaking mechanism.

### 3.2 Bell Inequality Violations

The framework is a hidden variable theory evading Bell's theorem [13] not by superdeterminism but by violating factorizability through P-indivisible joint dynamics — while remaining causally local. Two subsystems interacting at preparation carry a joint transition matrix $T_{QR} \neq T_Q \otimes T_R$. This non-factorizability *is* stochastic entanglement [10, 11, 14]. Since the process is indivisible, no well-defined intermediate conditional probabilities permit Bell's factorization.

In the Jarrett decomposition, the framework violates outcome independence while preserving parameter independence and measurement independence — precisely the class Fine's theorem [24] permits. Barandes, Hasan, and Kagan [14] prove the maximum CHSH correlator is exactly Tsirelson's bound $2\sqrt{2}$, with independent support from Le et al. [15]. The bound also follows from the Stinespring route: Appendix A establishes full unitary QM on a tensor-product Hilbert space, from which Tsirelson's original operator-norm argument [36] yields $|\langle S\rangle| \leq 2\sqrt{2}$; achievability follows because all quantum states, including maximally entangled ones, are realizable in the emergent description.

**Fine-tuning and causal structure.** The framework does not claim to restore Bell locality: outcome independence is genuinely violated. What it provides is a *derivation* of this nonlocality from the causal partition, rather than treating it as axiomatic. The fine-tuning objection (Wood and Spekkens, 2015) assumes DAG causal structure with Markov factorization; P-indivisible processes violate the Markov condition on any DAG, so the appropriate framework is the process tensor [8], within which no-signaling follows from marginalization structure without fine-tuning.

**Parameter independence from spatial locality.** Let $V_A$ and $V_B$ be space-like separated visible-sector subsystems with disjoint coupling neighborhoods on $G_\varphi$. The spatial Markov property of range-1 dynamics (Fundamental, §5, area-law lemma) makes $V_A$ and $V_B$ conditionally independent given boundary data. Alice's measurement setting $a$ determines which function she evaluates on $V_A$; it does not alter the transition probabilities for $V_B$, which depend only on $V_B$'s local coupling neighborhood. Hence $P(x_B \mid a,b) = P(x_B \mid b)$ — parameter independence holds structurally for all bounded-degree graph topologies with range-1 coupling, with no fine-tuning of the hidden-variable distribution. Combined with the outcome-independence violation from stochastic entanglement, this gives the precise Jarrett decomposition.

### 3.3 The Characterization Theorem: Necessity of the Conditions

The logical structure: Barandes' correspondence gives QM $\iff$ P-indivisibility. What remains is P-indivisibility $\implies$ embedded observation under (C1)–(C3).

**Dilation existence.** Any stochastic process on a finite configuration space can be realized as marginalization of a deterministic process on a larger state space — furnishing Axioms 1–4.

**Theorem (C1 equivalence).** *The marginalized process is P-indivisible iff $T$ is not a permutation matrix.*

*Proof.* Forward: §2.3. Reverse: if $T$ is a permutation, $\Lambda(k_2,k_1) = T^{(k_2-k_1)}$ is a valid stochastic matrix for all $k_2 > k_1 \Rightarrow$ P-divisible. □

**Theorem (C2 necessity).** *In the fast-bath regime ($\tau_B \ll \tau_S$), ergodic mixing drives the hidden sector to uniformity before each coupling event, yielding a Markov chain ($T^{(k)} = T^k$), which is P-divisible. Contrapositively, P-indivisibility requires $\tau_S \ll \tau_B$.*

*Proof.* Between coupling events (separated by $\tau_S$), the hidden sector evolves under its own Hamiltonian $H_H$. Let $\mathscr{L}_H$ denote the hidden-sector Liouvillian with spectral gap $\Delta > 0$ (guaranteed on a finite ergodic

system). For any conditioned hidden-sector distribution $\mu_H(\cdot|x_i)$ at a coupling event:

$$\|e^{\mathscr{L}_H \tau_S}\mu_H(\cdot|x_i) - \mu_{\text{eq}}\|_{\text{TV}} \leq C\, e^{-\Delta\tau_S}$$

In the fast-bath regime ($\Delta\tau_S \gg 1$), this is exponentially small: the hidden sector relaxes to equilibrium $\mu_{\text{eq}}$ before each coupling event regardless of its post-coupling state. Each single-step transition matrix $T$ is therefore computed against the same equilibrium distribution, so $T^{(k)} = T^k$ — a homogeneous Markov chain, hence P-divisible.

Contrapositively: P-indivisibility requires $\Delta\tau_S \lesssim 1$, i.e., $\tau_S \lesssim \tau_B$. For the strong, persistent P-indivisibility of the characterization theorem, the separation must be $\tau_S \ll \tau_B$. (The proof uses discrete coupling events; for continuous Hamiltonian flow, $\tau_S$ is the visible sector's dynamical timescale and $\Delta$ is the spectral gap of $\mathscr{L}_H$. The continuous-time extension replaces the collision-model structure with the continuous spectral condition $\Delta\tau_S \gg 1 \Rightarrow$ Markovian, established in [4, 9].) □

**Theorem (C3 necessity).** *Let $m = |\mathscr{C}_H|$. The non-Markovian mutual information satisfies:*

$$I(X_{<t}; X_{>t} \mid X_t) \leq \log_2 m$$

*Proof.* The total system is deterministic: $X_{>t}$ is a function of $(X_t, H_t)$. Conditioning on $X_t$: $X_{<t} \to H_t \to X_{>t}$ is a Markov chain. By data processing:

$$I(X_{<t}; X_{>t} \mid X_t) \leq I(X_{<t}; H_t \mid X_t) \leq H(H_t \mid X_t) \leq \log_2 m \quad \square$$

**Corollary.** P-indivisibility across $n$ visible configurations requires $m \geq n$, and persistence over $K$ transitions requires $m/n$ growing with the observation window — precisely (C3). □

**Definition (unitarily evolving QM).** A stochastic process $\mathscr{S}$ on a finite configuration space $\mathscr{C}_V = \{x_1, \ldots, x_n\}$ is *mathematically equivalent to unitarily evolving quantum mechanics* if there exists a Hilbert space $\mathscr{H}_V$ of dimension $\leq n^3$, a Hermitian operator $\hat{H}$ on $\mathscr{H}_V$, and a unitary family $U(t) = e^{-i\hat{H}t}$ such that $T_{ij}(t) = |U_{ij}(t)|^2$ for all $i, j, t$ — i.e., transition probabilities are exactly Born-rule probabilities. This definition captures the Hilbert space, unitary dynamics, and the Born rule. Additional quantum-mechanical structures — the tensor product decomposition for spatially separated visible-sector subsystems, state update, and the measurement formalism — are addressed in the remarks following the theorem.

**Characterization theorem.** *For $|\mathscr{C}_V| \geq 2$, the following are equivalent:*

*(i) $\mathscr{S}$ is mathematically equivalent to unitarily evolving QM (in the sense of the preceding definition).*

*(ii) $\mathscr{S}$ is P-indivisible.*

*(iii) $\mathscr{S}$ arises from marginalizing a deterministic bijection on $\mathscr{C}_V \times \mathscr{C}_H$ with (C1) non-trivial coupling, (C2) slow-bath memory, and (C3) sufficient capacity.*

*Proof.* (i) $\iff$ (ii): Barandes [10, 11]. (iii) $\implies$ (ii): §2.3. (ii) $\implies$ (iii): necessity theorems above. □

QM is not merely *compatible with* embedded observation — it is *equivalent to* it.

**Remark (scope of the equivalence).** The characterization theorem establishes the Hilbert space, unitary dynamics, and Born-rule transition probabilities. Four further structures of operational quantum mechanics merit comment.

*(i) Tensor product structure (visible–hidden).* The Stinespring route (Appendix A) constructs $\mathscr{H} = \mathscr{H}_V \otimes \mathscr{H}_H$ and derives the CPTP channel $\Phi$ by partial trace. The visible–hidden tensor product is therefore given by the construction, not postulated.

*(ii) Tensor product structure (visible-sector subsystems).* Spatially separated subsystems within the visible sector — e.g., two laboratories — correspond to subsets $V_A, V_B \subset V$ with disjoint coupling neighborhoods on the coupling graph (Fundamental, §3). The spatial Markov property of range-1 dynamics (Fundamental, §5, area-law lemma) guarantees conditional independence: $\rho_{AB} = \rho_A \otimes \rho_B$ conditioned on boundary data. The emergent Hilbert space inherits the factorization $\mathscr{H}_{V_A} \otimes \mathscr{H}_{V_B}$ from the locality of the coupling graph, with entanglement between $A$ and $B$ arising from shared boundary history — precisely the stochastic entanglement of [10, 14].

*(iii) State update, measurement, and multi-time predictions.* Projective measurement in the emergent description corresponds to conditioning on a visible-sector outcome and re-marginalizing over the hidden sector. The Lüders rule $\rho \to P_k \rho P_k / \mathrm{Tr}(P_k \rho)$ is the quantum transcription of Bayesian updating on the classical substratum (Axiom 4). No independent measurement postulate is required. Multi-time correlation functions, weak values, and Leggett-Garg inequalities are standard calculations within the delivered formalism ($\mathscr{H}_V$, $U(t)$, Born rule); they require no additional postulates beyond what the characterization theorem provides.

*(iv) Classical non-Markovianity and quantum mechanics.* The equivalence is not a claim that all P-indivisible processes are "secretly quantum" in some metaphysical sense; it is a theorem that the mathematical structures are identical. Classical systems exhibiting P-indivisibility — renewal processes, semi-Markov processes on finite state spaces — admit a unique unitary description (phase-locking lemma) that makes predictions beyond the transition data (energy eigenvalues, interference, entanglement), and can be realized as marginalization of deterministic dynamics under C1–C3 (necessity theorems). The framework does not distinguish "classical non-Markovian" from "quantum" — it proves they are the same category. The physical content of the unitary is not that of a mere mathematical embedding: it is the *specific* Hamiltonian uniquely determined by the transition data, arising from the *actual* dilation structure of the system (Appendix A).

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# PART II: THE COSMOLOGICAL APPLICATION

## 4. THE COSMOLOGICAL HORIZON AS CAUSAL PARTITION

### 4.1 The Partition

The cosmological horizon — the boundary beyond which no signal propagating at or below $c$ can reach the observer — implements the causal partition of Axiom 3: $\Gamma_V$ is the interior, $\Gamma_H$ everything beyond. This is a consequence of GR's causal structure, not a modeling choice. The universality of the observed quantum mechanics follows from all sub-$c$ observers sharing the same causal structure.

Different observers have different horizon areas (hence different $S_{\mathrm{dS}}$), but $\hbar = c^3 \varepsilon^2/(4G)$ depends only on local geometric quantities — not on the observer's worldline or horizon area — so all observers share the same emergent action scale.

### 4.2 Verification of the Conditions

**(C1)** In the ADM formulation, the bulk Hamiltonian is a sum of constraints that vanish on-shell; physical time evolution is generated by the boundary term at the horizon, which depends on data from both sides. The Hamiltonian and momentum constraints further correlate interior and exterior initial data on any Cauchy surface, so the physical phase space is a constraint surface within the kinematic product $\Gamma_V \times \Gamma_H$ (see §9.6 for implications). This is *stronger* than the $H_{\mathrm{int}} \neq 0$ required by Axiom 3: constraints enforce correlations that persist on all timescales and cannot be perturbatively removed. **Satisfied.**

**(C2)** $\tau_B \gtrsim 1/H \sim 10^{17}$ s; for laboratory processes, $\tau_S \sim 10^{-15}$ s. Ratio: $\tau_S/\tau_B \sim 10^{-32}$. **Satisfied.**

**(C3)** Hidden sector has $A/\varepsilon^2$ modes with $A \sim 10^{52}$ m$^2$; visible sector has $\sim 10^{80}$ baryons. No laboratory process saturates the hidden sector. **Satisfied.**

### 4.3 Application

Axiom 2 is now a consequence of partition geometry: the horizon has finite area $A = 4\pi c^2/H^2$, bounding coupled modes to $A/\varepsilon^2 < \infty$. The Part I theorem applies: the observer's reduced description is P-indivisible and, by Barandes' correspondence, equivalent to unitary QM with $\hbar$ determined by the partition boundary.

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## 5. DERIVATION OF THE EMERGENT ACTION SCALE ($\hbar$)

### 5.1 The Classical Horizon Temperature

Jacobson [16] showed $dE = T\,dS$ applied to local causal horizons yields Einstein's equations, with $dE = (c^2\kappa/8\pi G)\,dA$, where $\kappa$ is the surface gravity of the horizon. The entropy density is $\eta = 1/\varepsilon^2$ — one coupled mode per minimal cell. This is not an assumption about the number of states per cell but a consequence of two results: $\varepsilon$ is defined as the minimal distinguishable scale (Axiom 2), so each cell of area $\varepsilon^2$ contributes exactly one boundary mode that couples across the partition; the number of internal states per mode (the alphabet size $q$) is a gauge freedom with no observable consequences (Fundamental, §4). Thus $dS = dA/\varepsilon^2$. Equating:

$$T_{\text{cl}} = \frac{c^2\varepsilon^2\kappa}{8\pi G k_B}$$

For de Sitter ($\kappa = cH$): $k_B T_{\text{cl}} = c^3\varepsilon^2 H/(8\pi G)$. No $\hbar$ appears.

### 5.2 The Emergent Action Scale

**Step 1: Uniqueness.** By partition-relativity (§1.4), $\hbar$ is derived, not free.

**Step 2: $\hbar$ is structural, not volumetric.**

**Lemma (Boundary-only dependence).** *Decompose the hidden sector as $\mathscr{C}_H = \mathscr{C}_B \times \mathscr{C}_D$, where $\mathscr{C}_B$ denotes boundary modes (within the interaction range of $H_{int}$) and $\mathscr{C}_D$ denotes deep modes (the remainder of the hidden sector). If the classical Hamiltonian is spatially local, then on timescales $t \ll \tau_B$:*

$$T_{ij}(t) = T_{ij}^{(B)}(t) + \mathscr{O}(t/\tau_B)$$

*where $T_{ij}^{(B)}$ depends only on the $V$-$B$ dynamics.*

*Proof.* (i) *Coupling structure.* Spatial locality of the classical Hamiltonian implies the interaction decomposes as $H_{\text{tot}} = H_V + H_B + H_D + H_{VB} + H_{BD}$, with no direct $V$-$D$ coupling: a deep hidden-sector mode must propagate through the boundary layer before influencing the visible sector. The coupling chain is $V \leftrightarrow B \leftrightarrow D$, not $V \leftrightarrow D$.

(ii) *Frozen deep sector.* Let $\Delta_D$ be the spectral gap of $H_D + H_{BD}$ restricted to the deep sector conditioned on a fixed boundary configuration. The deep-sector evolution over time $t$ displaces any initial configuration by $\mathscr{O}(\Delta_D t)$ in phase space. By condition (C2), $\Delta_D \sim 1/\tau_B$, so for $t \ll \tau_B$: $\|\varphi_t^D - \text{id}\| = \mathscr{O}(t/\tau_B)$.

(iii) *Factorization of the Liouville integral.* The transition probability is:

$$T_{ij}(t) = \frac{1}{|\mathscr{C}_B||\mathscr{C}_D|} \sum_{b\in\mathscr{C}_B} \sum_{d\in\mathscr{C}_D} \delta_{x_j}[\pi_V(\varphi_t(x_i,b,d))]$$

By (i), $\pi_V(\varphi_t(x_i,b,d))$ depends on $d$ only through the back-reaction $B \leftarrow D$, which by (ii) shifts $b$ by $\mathscr{O}(t/\tau_B)$. Expanding:

$$\pi_V(\varphi_t(x_i,b,d)) = \pi_V(\varphi_t^{VB}(x_i,b)) + \mathscr{O}(t/\tau_B)$$

where $\varphi_t^{VB}$ is the flow restricted to $V \times B$ with $D$ frozen. The $d$-sum then contributes $|\mathscr{C}_D|$ identical terms at leading order:

$$T_{ij}(t) = \underbrace{\frac{1}{|\mathscr{C}_B|} \sum_{b\in\mathscr{C}_B} \delta_{x_j}[\pi_V(\varphi_t^{VB}(x_i,b))]}_{T_{ij}^{(B)}(t)} + \mathscr{O}(t/\tau_B) \qquad \square$$

The correction is $\mathscr{O}(t/\tau_B) \sim 10^{-32}$ for laboratory processes. Since $T_{ij}(t)$ determines the emergent quantum description (§3.1), and $T_{ij}^{(B)}(t)$ depends only on the $V$-$B$ dynamics — which are characterized by the boundary geometry ($A$, $\varepsilon$, $\kappa$) and the constants $c$, $G$ appearing in the classical Hamiltonian — the emergent action scale $\hbar$ inherits boundary-only dependence.

**Corollary (deep-sector cardinality is gauge).** *No observable of the emergent description — no transition probability, emergent Hamiltonian eigenvalue, or scattering amplitude — depends on the cardinality $|\mathscr{C}_D|$ of the deep hidden sector. Systems with the same $\mathscr{C}_V \times \mathscr{C}_B$ dynamics produce the same emergent physics to within $\mathscr{O}(\tau_S/\tau_B)$, whether $|\mathscr{C}_D|$ is finite, countably infinite, or uncountably infinite.*

*Proof.* $T_{ij}^{(B)}(t)$ is defined by a sum over $\mathscr{C}_B$ alone. The $\mathscr{C}_D$-dependent terms enter only through the $\mathscr{O}(t/\tau_B)$ back-reaction. Since the emergent Hamiltonian $\hat{H}_{\text{eff}}$ is uniquely determined by $\{T_{ij}(t)\}$ (phase-locking lemma, §3.1; D-gauge theorem, §5.3), it inherits $\mathscr{C}_D$-independence at leading order. All observables — eigenvalues, transition amplitudes, scattering cross-sections — are functions of $\hat{H}_{\text{eff}}$ and therefore $\mathscr{C}_D$-independent. $\square$

The cardinality of the deep hidden sector is gauge in the same technical sense as the alphabet size $q$ (Fundamental, §4): just as two systems with different $q$ are physically equivalent if they share the same coupling structure, two systems with different $|\mathscr{C}_D|$ are physically equivalent if they share the same $\mathscr{C}_V \times \mathscr{C}_B$ dynamics. Axiom 2 requires $S$ finite for the recurrence proof (§2.3); the corollary establishes that the deep sector's contribution to this finiteness has no observable consequences. The question "is the universe finite or infinite?" has no empirical content within the framework — it is identified as gauge.

**Step 3: Dimensional determination.** Step 2 excludes volumetric (deep-sector) quantities, leaving boundary quantities. The boundary carries both *local* geometric data ($\varepsilon$, $\kappa$, and the constants $c$, $G$ of the classical Hamiltonian) and a *global* quantity: the total area $A$, which forms the dimensionless ratio $A/\varepsilon^2 = S_{\text{dS}}$. If $\hbar$ depended on $S_{\text{dS}}$, it would be observer-dependent — different observers have different horizon areas (§4.1) — contradicting the universality of the emergent action scale. (All sub-$c$ observers share the same local physics and hence the same $\hbar$; §4.1.) This excludes $A$, leaving the local boundary quantities $c$, $G$, $\varepsilon$, and $\kappa$. Since $\kappa$ is the surface gravity of a specific horizon (observer-dependent, like $A$), it too is excluded. The unique combination of $c$, $G$, $\varepsilon$ with dimensions of action:

$$\hbar = \beta \frac{c^3\varepsilon^2}{G}$$

**Step 4: Thermal self-consistency.** The classical substratum assigns the partition boundary a temperature $k_B T_{\rm cl} = c^3\varepsilon^2\kappa/(8\pi G)$ (§5.1), containing no $\hbar$. The emergent QFT of Part I lives on this classical background, which has a bifurcate Killing horizon with surface gravity $\kappa$. Regularity of the Wick-rotated metric at the horizon requires Euclidean period $\beta = 2\pi c/\kappa$; any QFT on this background — including a lattice-regularized one — must therefore be periodic in imaginary time with the same period, giving a KMS state at temperature $T_Q = \hbar\kappa/(2\pi c k_B)$, with $\hbar$ unknown. This is a theorem *within* the derived QFT, not an external import. The two temperatures are computed independently — $T_{\rm cl}$ from the classical substratum alone (no QM), $T_Q$ from the emergent QFT alone (no classical substratum details) — but they describe the same physical degrees of freedom: the boundary modes across which the partition is defined. Since the quantum description is derived from the classical one (Part I), and the derivation is exact at the boundary (Step 2's correction is $\mathscr{O}(\tau_S/\tau_B) \sim 10^{-32}$), the two descriptions cannot assign contradictory temperatures to the same boundary. Consistency requires $T_{\rm cl} = T_Q$:

$$\frac{c^3\varepsilon^2\kappa}{8\pi G} = \frac{\hbar\kappa}{2\pi c}$$

$\kappa$ cancels (confirming the structural/volumetric distinction). Solving:

$$\boxed{\hbar = \frac{c^3\varepsilon^2}{4G}}$$

The derivation is a gap equation: $\varepsilon$ is the free geometric input, $\hbar$ is the output. The match is non-trivial: $T_{\rm cl}$ could have depended on volumetric hidden-sector data (excluded by Step 2), or $T_Q$ could have depended on the state (it does not — the KMS temperature is purely kinematic). That neither pathology obtains makes the gap equation a genuine determination. The non-circularity is structural: Part I establishes that a QFT emerges with *some* action scale $\hbar$; §5 determines *which* $\hbar$, using the independent classical temperature that Part I neither requires nor produces.

**Non-circularity of the entropy density.** The claim $\eta = 1/\varepsilon^2$ — one mode per minimal cell — may appear to pre-bake the area-entropy proportionality. To see why it does not, consider the counterfactual: suppose the classical entropy density were $\eta = \alpha/\varepsilon^2$ for arbitrary $\alpha > 0$. Then $T_{\rm cl} = \alpha c^2\varepsilon^2\kappa/(8\pi G k_B)$, and thermal matching gives $\hbar = \alpha c^3\varepsilon^2/(4G)$. The Bekenstein-Hawking entropy becomes $S = A/(4\alpha^{-1}l_p^2)$, which reproduces the observed $1/4$ factor only for $\alpha = 1$. Thus $\alpha = 1$ is a non-trivial constraint — it says that each minimal cell contributes exactly one boundary mode, not a fractional or multiple contribution. This is the physical content of the $q$-gauge theorem (Fundamental, §4): the alphabet size $q$ (the number of internal states per cell) is observationally irrelevant, so what counts is the number of *cells*, not the number of *states*. The counting $\eta = 1/\varepsilon^2$ is not an assumption about mode density but a consequence of $\varepsilon$ being defined as the minimal distinguishable scale (Axiom 2) combined with the irrelevance of sub-cell structure.

The predictive content lies not in the gap equation alone but in its consequences. The specific relationship $\hbar = c^3\varepsilon^2/(4G)$ — rather than any other function of $c$, $G$, $\varepsilon$ — produces: the Bekenstein-Hawking formula with the exact factor $1/4$ (§6), the CC dissolution with $S_{\rm dS}$ as the compression ratio (§7.3), the RVM parameter $\nu_{\rm OI}$ (§8.1), and the GW echo timescale (§8.2). Any alternative $\hbar(\varepsilon)$ would fail at least one of these checks. The situation is analogous to deriving the Schwarzschild metric with $M$ as a free parameter: the derivation has genuine content (the functional form) even though one input is not determined from within.

Jacobson's original derivation [16] uses $\hbar$-containing forms; this paper does not — it uses the classical identity $dE = (c^2\kappa/8\pi G)\,dA$ and the classical entropy density $\eta = 1/\varepsilon^2$. The logical ordering differs from Jacobson's: his argument derives $G$ from $\eta$ and $\hbar$; the present argument takes $G$ as a parameter of the classical Hamiltonian (Axiom 1) and derives $\hbar$ from $G$ and $\varepsilon$. The two are consistent — substituting

$\eta = 1/\varepsilon^2$ and $\hbar = c^3\varepsilon^2/(4G)$ into Jacobson's formula $G_{\text{eff}} = c^4/(8\pi\eta \cdot \hbar c)$ recovers $G_{\text{eff}} = G$ — but the roles of input and output are reversed. The Gibbons-Hawking temperature [17] $k_B T_{\text{GH}} = \hbar\kappa/(2\pi c)$ is recovered as a prediction, not used as an input. The KMS condition used above is derived for continuum QFT on bifurcate Killing horizons; for the lattice-regularized theory emerging from Part I, the relevant result is that thermal periodicity of the Euclidean Green's functions is robust against UV modifications of the dispersion relation, with corrections at $\mathcal{O}((\varepsilon\kappa/c)^2)$ [28, 29]. For the cosmological horizon, $\varepsilon\kappa/c = \varepsilon H/c \sim 10^{-61}$, so lattice corrections are $\sim 10^{-122}$.

### 5.3 Gauge-Fixing and the Dimensional Obstruction

Steps 1–2 establish that $\hbar$ depends only on boundary quantities; Step 4 will fix its value via thermal matching. A prior question must be addressed: does the transition-probability data $\{T_{ij}(t)\}$ determine the emergent Hamiltonian uniquely, or does residual gauge freedom leave $\hbar$ underdetermined? The following theorem, completing the phase-locking argument of §3.1, shows the gauge freedom is physically trivial.

**Theorem (D-gauge completeness).** *Let $U(t) = e^{-iHt}$ with non-degenerate eigenvalues and non-vanishing configuration-basis overlaps. If $|U'_{ij}(t)|^2 = |U_{ij}(t)|^2$ for all $i, j, t$, then $H' = DHD^\dagger$ for a time-independent diagonal unitary $D$.*

*Proof.* Write $U_{ij}(t) = \sum_a V_{ia}\, e^{-iE_a t}\, V^*_{ja}$ with $V_{ia} = \langle i|a\rangle$ and eigenvalues $\{E_a\}$, and similarly $U'_{ij}(t) = \sum_a V'_{ia}\, e^{-iE'_a t}\, V'^*_{ja}$.

*Step 1 (Eigenvalue recovery).* By the phase-locking argument of §3.1, $|U_{ij}(t)|^2 = |U'_{ij}(t)|^2$ for all $t$ implies, via Fourier analysis, that the frequency sets $\{E_a - E_b\}$ and $\{E'_a - E'_b\}$ coincide. Non-degeneracy of energy gaps then gives $E'_a = E_{\sigma(a)} + E_0$ for some permutation $\sigma$ and global shift $E_0$. The Fourier coefficients $a^{kl}_{ij} = V_{ik}V^*_{jk}V_{jl}V^*_{il}$ must match between primed and unprimed, which (by the non-vanishing condition on overlaps) forces $\sigma = \text{id}$ up to relabeling. Thus $E'_a = E_a + E_0$.

*Step 2 (Modulus recovery).* From the diagonal Fourier coefficients $a^{kl}_{ii} = |V_{ik}|^2|V_{il}|^2$, the non-vanishing condition gives $|V'_{ia}| = |V_{ia}|$ for all $i, a$.

*Step 3 (Phase structure).* Write $V'_{ia} = V_{ia}\, e^{i\delta_{ia}}$. The off-diagonal Fourier coefficients require:

$$V'_{ik}V'^*_{jk}V'_{jl}V'^*_{il} = V_{ik}V^*_{jk}V_{jl}V^*_{il}$$

Substituting and canceling moduli:

$$e^{i(\delta_{ik} - \delta_{jk} - \delta_{il} + \delta_{jl})} = 1 \quad \text{for all } i, j, k, l$$

This is the double-difference condition: $\delta_{ik} - \delta_{il} - \delta_{jk} + \delta_{jl} = 0 \pmod{2\pi}$. The general solution on the integer lattice is $\delta_{ia} = \alpha_i + \beta_a$ for phases $\{\alpha_i\}$, $\{\beta_a\}$. Thus $V' = D_\alpha V D_\beta$ where $D_\alpha = \text{diag}(e^{i\alpha_i})$ and $D_\beta = \text{diag}(e^{i\beta_a})$. The $D_\beta$ factor is absorbed into the eigenvector phase convention (physically irrelevant), giving $H' = D_\alpha H D_\alpha^\dagger$ with $D = D_\alpha$ a time-independent diagonal unitary. □

The D-gauge is physically trivial (basis rephasing). Cross-interval transition probabilities fix the relative gauge up to a single global phase; in the continuum limit this becomes an unobservable smooth function $e^{i\theta(t)}$.

**Dimensional obstruction.** The unitary $U(t)$ is dimensionless; $\hbar$ enters only via $\hat{H} = i\hbar\,\partial_t U \cdot U^\dagger$. No dimensionless data can fix a dimensionful constant — Step 4's thermal self-consistency provides the necessary dimensionful input.

**Remark (phase recovery under discrete sampling).** The spatial lattice discreteness does not discretize time: the continuous-time extension (§2.3) provides $T_{ij}(t)$ as a genuinely continuous function of $t$ via the

Liouville marginalization of the Hamiltonian flow (Axiom 1). The D-gauge theorem therefore applies to the continuous object without aliasing corrections. Aliasing would arise only if the observer sampled $T_{ij}$ at discrete intervals, in which case trans-Planckian frequencies could be misidentified — but these lie outside the emergent QFT's domain. The phase-recovery error is controlled by the same $\mathcal{O}(\tau_S/\tau_B) \sim 10^{-32}$ suppression that governs the boundary-only dependence of §5.2.

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## 6. SELF-CONSISTENCY AND THE DISCRETENESS SCALE

Rearranging $\hbar = c^3\varepsilon^2/(4G)$:

$$\varepsilon^2 = \frac{4\hbar G}{c^3} = 4\,l_p^2$$

The framework yields $\varepsilon = 2\,l_p$ exactly. This is algebraically equivalent to the formula for $\hbar$: the framework contains one free geometric parameter ($\varepsilon$), and thermal self-consistency establishes its relationship to $\hbar$. The result is a self-consistency condition constraining $\varepsilon$ to the Planck regime, not an independent determination. If $\varepsilon^2 \ll l_p^2$, sub-Planckian subcells would create a second trace-out, breaking the single-valuedness of $\hbar$. If $\varepsilon^2 \gg l_p^2$, the emergent description would assign distinct quantum states to physically identical configurations. The framework's predictive content comes from the relationship $\hbar = c^3\varepsilon^2/(4G)$, the Bekenstein-Hawking formula, and the consequences that follow.

With $\varepsilon = 2\,l_p$, the number of independent modes on the cosmological horizon is:

$$N_{\text{modes}} = \frac{A}{\varepsilon^2} = \frac{A}{4\,l_p^2} = S_{\text{dS}}$$

where $S_{\text{dS}} = A/(4\,l_p^2)$ is the Bekenstein-Hawking entropy of the de Sitter horizon. The factor of $1/4$ in the Bekenstein-Hawking formula — historically introduced as a proportionality constant — is here derived: each minimal cell of area $\varepsilon^2 = 4\,l_p^2$ on the horizon contributes one unit of entropy, and $A/(4\,l_p^2) = A/\varepsilon^2$ recovers the standard formula exactly.

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## 7. DISSOLUTION OF THE COSMOLOGICAL CONSTANT PROBLEM

### 7.1 The Two Levels of Description

**From finite-dimensional QM to QFT.** Part I delivers QM on a finite-dimensional Hilbert space. The $N = A/\varepsilon^2$ cells discretize the visible sector; spatial locality of the classical substratum restricts which cells interact on any given timescale. The emergent Hilbert space decomposes as $\mathscr{H} = \bigotimes_k \mathscr{H}_k$ — a lattice-regularized QFT with UV cutoff at $\varepsilon = 2\,l_p$. The tensor product structure follows from the spatial product structure of the classical configuration space $\mathscr{C}_V = \mathscr{C}_1 \times \cdots \times \mathscr{C}_N$ (one factor per cell), which is not required by Axiom 2 but is a consequence of spatial locality in the classical substratum: each cell's configuration is a local degree of freedom.

**Locality preservation theorem.** *If the classical Hamiltonian is spatially local (couples only neighbors), then the emergent quantum Hamiltonian inherits spatial locality.*

*Proof.* For infinitesimal $dt$ and $x' \neq x$: $T_{x,x'}(dt) = |\langle x'|\hat{H}|x\rangle|^2\,dt^2 + O(dt^3)$. If $x, x'$ differ at non-neighboring sites, spatial locality of the classical dynamics gives $T_{x,x'}(dt) = 0$ at leading order, hence $|\langle x'|\hat{H}|x\rangle|^2 = 0$. By the D-gauge theorem (§5.3), the residual phase freedom is a diagonal unitary $D$ that preserves the vanishing of off-diagonal moduli, so $\langle x'|\hat{H}|x\rangle = 0$ in any gauge. The emergent Hamiltonian has the form $\hat{H} = \sum_k \hat{h}_k + \sum_{\langle k,l\rangle} \hat{h}_{kl}$. □

**Scope of the emergent QFT.** The CC dissolution requires only that the emergent description assigns zero-point energy $\sim \hbar\omega/2$ per mode with UV cutoff at $\varepsilon^{-1}$ — a property shared by any lattice QFT with local couplings, regardless of gauge group or matter content. The framework's predictions in Part II ($\hbar$, $S_{\rm dS}$, $\nu_{\rm OI}$) depend on partition geometry, not on the emergent field content.

**Classical substratum** (what geometric measurements probe): The horizon has classical thermal equilibrium. By the Friedmann equation, $\rho_{\rm crit} = 3H^2c^2/(8\pi G)$. No zero-point energy, no discrepancy. Total vacuum energy density: $\rho \sim H^2/G \sim 10^{-9}$ J/m$^3$ — precisely observed.

**Emergent QFT** (what local quantum measurements probe): Zero-point energy $\frac{1}{2}\hbar\omega$ per mode summed to the Planck cutoff gives $\rho_{\rm QFT} \sim 10^{113}$ J/m$^3$ — a $\sim 10^{122}$ discrepancy with the observed value [2, 3, 18].

### 7.2 Why Gravity Sees the Classical Value

Spacetime geometry is part of the classical substratum (Axiom 3): the metric evolves via Einstein's equations *before* the trace-out. The stress-energy sourcing gravity is the classical stress-energy of the total microstate, not the expectation value of an emergent quantum operator. The semiclassical equation $G_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G\langle\hat{T}_{\mu\nu}\rangle$ is itself an emergent approximation; at the classical level, the gravitational field equations never encounter the zero-point sum.

**Ontological commitment.** Classical spacetime is fundamental; QM is emergent. This ordering is not a modeling choice but is forced by the logical structure of the derivation through three independent requirements:

*(i) Definiteness.* The trace-out that produces QM is defined by a *specific* partition $\Gamma = \Gamma_V \times \Gamma_H$. The partition must be definite — not in superposition, not subject to quantum uncertainty — for the marginalization integral (§1.4) to be well-defined. A partition in superposition would yield an incoherent mixture of inequivalent quantum theories, not a single QM. The metric at the partition boundary must therefore be classical.

*(ii) Non-circularity.* The partition is defined by the causal structure: $\Gamma_H$ is the set of degrees of freedom beyond the observer's causal reach (§4.1). Causal structure is determined by null geodesics of the metric. If the metric were derived from QM, then the derivation would require: QM $\to$ metric $\to$ causal structure $\to$ partition $\to$ QM — a circular dependency with no entry point. The circle breaks only if the metric exists prior to the partition.

*(iii) Uniqueness of $\hbar$.* The emergent action scale is determined by the boundary geometry (§5.2). If the geometry were itself quantum-mechanical, $\hbar$ would depend on a quantum state — but $\hbar$ is state-independent by observation. The geometry-first ordering is the only one consistent with a universal $\hbar$.

Any framework in which QM is logically prior to the metric must either (a) treat the zero-point sum as a gravitational source — producing the $10^{122}$ discrepancy requiring cancellation or fine-tuning — or (b) invoke an independent mechanism to decouple quantum vacuum energy from gravity. In the present framework, the zero-point sum is an artifact of the emergent description and never enters the stress-energy tensor; no decoupling mechanism is needed.

**Cumulative evidence for the ordering.** The geometry-first ordering produces six independent consequences that match observation, none of which were designed into the axioms: (1) the CC dissolution — the observed vacuum energy sits at $\rho \sim H^2/G$, the classical baseline, without fine-tuning (§7.3); (2) the Bekenstein-Hawking formula including the $1/4$ factor, derived from $\varepsilon = 2l_p$ (§6); (3) the value of $\hbar$, determined by partition geometry rather than treated as a free parameter (§5.2); (4) the dark-sector concordance — ~95% of $\rho_{\rm crit}$ is invisible to QFT, matching the observed dark sector (§8.3); (5) dark energy evolution with $\nu_{\rm OI}$ in the range consistent with DESI data (§8.1); (6) a testable GW echo prediction at the discreteness scale (§8.2). Quantum-first orderings produce the $10^{122}$ discrepancy, have no natural account of the dark sector, and treat $\hbar$ and the $1/4$ factor as unexplained inputs. The cumulative case is

not a single tiebreaker but a pattern: every quantitative output of the geometry-first ordering is consistent with observation; the central quantitative output of the quantum-first ordering is the worst prediction in physics.

**The classical vacuum energy scale.** The framework does not explain *why* $\rho \sim H^2/G$; this is set by initial conditions via the Friedmann equation. What it does is reclassify the CC puzzle: from quantum vacuum cancellation to classical initial conditions. The two problems are not equivalent. The QFT CC problem requires a cancellation between independent contributions — the bare cosmological constant and the zero-point energies of every field — accurate to 122 decimal places, re-tuned at each order in perturbation theory. The initial-conditions question asks why a single parameter ($\Lambda$, or equivalently $H$) takes its observed value; the scale $\rho \sim H^2/G$ is the natural energy density of classical cosmology, not a fine-tuned cancellation between unrelated quantities. The framework eliminates the 122-digit cancellation entirely; the remaining question — why $H$ takes its value — is a standard cosmological problem addressable by inflationary dynamics or other initial-conditions mechanisms.

**Quantum corrections to gravity.** The emergent quantum description does feed back into gravitational dynamics through state-level quantities: §8.1 derives dark energy evolution because the emergent vacuum energy depends on $H$ through the hidden sector's volume. What the framework excludes is the zero-point sum as a gravitational source. The zero-point energy is the ground-state eigenvalue of the emergent Hamiltonian $\hat{H}_{\text{eff}}$, which acts on $\mathscr{H}_V$. But gravity is sourced by the classical Hamiltonian $H_{\text{tot}}$, which acts on the full phase space $\Gamma$ — and $\hat{H}_{\text{eff}}$ and $H_{\text{tot}}$ are not the same operator. The eigenvalues of $\hat{H}_{\text{eff}}$ (including the zero-point energy) are properties of the *emergent description*; the energy that $H_{\text{tot}}$ assigns to the corresponding classical microstates is the *classical vacuum energy* $\rho \sim H^2/G$. The Equivalence Principle applies to $H_{\text{tot}}$: everything that contributes to $H_{\text{tot}}$ gravitates. The zero-point sum does not contribute to $H_{\text{tot}}$; it appears when the classical transition probabilities are reorganized into the Hilbert space formalism (§3.1), not when the classical dynamics is evolved. The structural/volumetric distinction of §5.2 captures this: $\hbar$ (structural, a property of the correspondence) does not gravitate; the vacuum energy (volumetric, state-dependent, a property of $H_{\text{tot}}$) does, but at the classical scale $\rho \sim H^2/G$ rather than $\rho \sim M_{\text{Pl}}^4$.

### 7.3 The Structural Origin of the $10^{122}$ Discrepancy

$\rho_{\text{QFT}}/\rho_{\text{classical}} \sim M_{\text{Pl}}^4/(H^2/G) = S_{\text{dS}} = A/(4\,l_p^2)$ — the Bekenstein-Hawking entropy, now identified as the information compression ratio of the trace-out. The "worst prediction in physics" is the entropy of the observer's blind spot — a category error, not a fine-tuning failure. Wolpert's limits of inference [19] confirm this cannot be resolved from within: both geometric and quantum measurements are faithful to their respective descriptions, and no embedded observer can determine which is more fundamental. This is not a prediction awaiting future data — the observed vacuum energy sits at the classical geometric scale $\rho \sim H^2/G$, the value the framework expects.

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## 8. PREDICTIONS AND TESTS

### 8.1 Dark Energy Evolution in Running Vacuum Form

$\hbar$ is $H$-independent (§5.2), but the emergent vacuum energy is a state-level quantity depending on the hidden sector's volume. Expanding $\Lambda_{\text{eff}}(H)$:

$$\Lambda_{\text{eff}}(H) = \Lambda_0 + \frac{3\nu_{\text{OI}}}{8\pi G}(H^2 - H_0^2) + \mathscr{O}((H^2 - H_0^2)^2)$$

This is the Running Vacuum Model [20, 21]. The $S_{\text{dS}}$ horizon modes span frequencies $\omega_{\text{IR}} = H$ to $\omega_{\text{UV}} = c/\varepsilon$. For conformal fields, the spectral density is uniform in $\ln\omega$, so the number of independent

spectral channels is $\mathcal{N}(H) = \ln(c/\varepsilon H)$. Each carries fraction $1/\mathcal{N}$ of the total gravitating vacuum energy, so $\rho_\Lambda \propto 1/\mathcal{N}$. Taylor-expanding:

$$\boxed{\nu_{\rm OI} = \frac{\Omega_\Lambda}{2\ln(c/\varepsilon H_0)}}$$

With $\varepsilon = 2l_p$, $H_0 = 67.4$ km/s/Mpc, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.685$: $\nu_{\rm OI} = 2.45 \times 10^{-3}$ (parametric uncertainty $\pm 0.03 \times 10^{-3}$ from $H_0$ and $\Omega_\Lambda$; systematic range $\sim 1$–$5 \times 10^{-3}$ from the spectral assumption below). Independently testable ratio: $\nu_{\rm OI}/\Omega_\Lambda \approx 0.00358$.

**Sensitivity to field content.** The conformal assumption (uniform spectral density in $\ln\omega$) is an idealization; massive fields and QCD confinement break conformal invariance. For a spectral density $\propto \omega^\alpha$ with $\alpha \neq 0$, the effective channel count $\mathcal{N}$ is modified. Since $\nu_{\rm OI} \propto 1/\mathcal{N}$ and the conformal value is $\mathcal{N} \sim 140$, even order-unity changes to $\alpha$ shift $\nu_{\rm OI}$ within $\mathcal{O}(10^{-3})$: the logarithmic structure suppresses sensitivity to UV field content. The systematic range $1$–$5 \times 10^{-3}$ spans a factor-of-two variation in $\mathcal{N}$ around the conformal value; this is the dominant uncertainty, not the parametric error. The central value $2.45 \times 10^{-3}$ should be understood as the conformal benchmark, not a precision prediction.

DESI data [22, 30] report evolving dark energy at $2.8\sigma$–$4.2\sigma$. RVM fits [31] find $\nu \sim \mathcal{O}(10^{-3})$ with $\nu = 0$ disfavored at $2.7\sigma$–$3.1\sigma$, consistent with the prediction.

### 8.2 Gravitational Wave Echoes

A black hole horizon represents a regime where the causal partition differs from the cosmological one: degrees of freedom reclassify from visible to hidden sector as they cross the horizon, shifting the effective partition and the emergent description.

At proper distance $\sim \varepsilon$ outside a black hole horizon $r_h$, an infalling mode reaches the discreteness floor and must scatter back. The predicted time delay is:

$$\Delta t_{\rm echo} \approx \frac{r_h}{c} \ln\left(\frac{r_h}{2l_p}\right)$$

For a $30M_\odot$ remnant, logarithmic dependence on $\varepsilon$ makes this robust ($\sim 0.1$ ms shift within the $\sim 54$ ms timescale [23]). Detection would constitute direct evidence that $\varepsilon$ has observable consequences at horizons other than the cosmological one — a regime where partition-relativity (§1.4) becomes empirically accessible. Joint confirmation of dark energy evolution *and* GW echoes would uniquely favor an information-theoretic origin, since standard RVMs predict $\Lambda(H)$ running but have no mechanism for discreteness-scale echoes.

### 8.3 The Dark-Sector Corollary

The trace-out that produces QM has an automatic gravitational consequence.

**Corollary (Invisible gravitational budget).** *Under Axioms 1–4 and conditions (C1)–(C3), the cosmological trace-out that produces quantum mechanics simultaneously renders ~95% of the universe's gravitational budget invisible to the emergent QFT.*

*Proof.* Three steps, each using only results already established.

*(i) Total effective density.* The horizon carries $S_{\rm dS} = A/\varepsilon^2$ modes (§6). The classical temperature is $T_{\rm cl} = c^3\varepsilon^2 H/(8\pi G k_B)$ (§5.1), computed entirely within the classical substratum with no reference to $\hbar$ or the emergent quantum description. The total thermal energy is $E_s = S_{\rm dS} \cdot k_B T_{\rm cl}$. By the shell theorem, distributing over $V_H = 4\pi c^3/(3H^3)$:

$$\rho_s = \frac{E_s}{V_H} = \frac{A}{\varepsilon^2} \cdot \frac{c^3\varepsilon^2 H}{8\pi G} \cdot \frac{3H^3}{4\pi c^3} = \frac{3c^2H^2}{8\pi G} = \rho_{\text{crit}}$$

This identity, which Verlinde [37] assumes, is here derived.

*(ii) Invisibility.* The boundary modes comprising $S_{\text{dS}}$ are hidden-sector degrees of freedom — the variables traced out to produce the quantum description. No hidden-sector degree of freedom maps to an operator on $\mathscr{H}_V$. The gravitational influence of the boundary entropy therefore has no source in $\langle \hat{T}_{\mu\nu} \rangle$. This follows from Part I's trace-out structure alone; the gravitational consequence (additional gravity with no particle-sector source) follows from the geometry-first ordering of §7.2, which is already required by Part II's logic.

*(iii) Budget.* The emergent QFT accounts for the baryonic sector (~5% of $\rho_{\text{crit}}$). The remaining ~95% is boundary entropy — gravitationally active (because $\rho_s$ is a classical quantity computed before the trace-out, unlike $\rho_{\text{QFT}} \sim M_{\text{Pl}}^4$ which is an artifact of the emergent description) but invisible to the emergent QFT. This matches the observed composition, in which ~95% of the gravitational content has no source in particle physics. □

The corollary is a consistency check, not a derivation of the dark sector's internal structure. The uniform component of the boundary entropy corresponds to dark energy (§7); whether matter-induced redistribution of the boundary entropy produces observable local effects — and if so, whether the redistribution profile accounts for the structured component (dark matter) — requires a quantitative force law beyond Axioms 1–4 [37] and is deferred to future work. The ratio $\rho_{\text{QFT}}/\rho_s \sim S_{\text{dS}} \sim 10^{122}$ confirms the parallel with §7.3: the information compression ratio and the gravitational occlusion fraction are two aspects of a single phenomenon.

**Falsifiability.** The corollary would be falsified by detection of dark matter particles accounting for the full ~27% structured dark sector, or by evidence that the dark sector's gravitational effects are unrelated to the boundary geometry.

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## 9. DISCUSSION

### 9.1 Interpretive Consequences

In the cosmological application, the hidden sector is the trans-horizon region; the degrees of freedom involved in quantum experiments — photons, electrons, slits, detectors — are all visible-sector objects. Their quantum behavior is a downstream consequence of the single cosmological trace-out: the emergent quantum mechanics, once established by the theorem, governs all visible-sector dynamics.

In the double-slit experiment, the particle traverses a single slit in the deterministic substratum. The interference pattern arises because opening or closing the second slit changes the boundary conditions of the transition matrix, altering the distribution of detection events. A which-path detector at one slit couples the trajectory to additional visible-sector degrees of freedom, changing the transition matrix and eliminating the interference terms. In Wigner's friend, the Friend has a definite outcome; Wigner's superposition reflects his epistemic deficit. The Everettian measure problem dissolves: the system evolves as a single reality; "branches" are features of the compressed description. The Born rule, often treated as an independent postulate, is derived: it is the equilibrium distribution of the indivisible stochastic process (§3.1), not an additional assumption.

### 9.2 Scope

The characterization theorem is a full equivalence: QM $\iff$ embedded observation under (C1)–(C3). The theorem does not identify which physical systems satisfy the conditions (empirical) nor derive $\hbar$ for

specific systems (requires Part II). Universality in our universe follows from the shared causal partition defined by null geodesics.

### 9.3 The Status of the Discreteness Scale

$\varepsilon$ does not smuggle in a quantum assumption. Axiom 2 requires finite-dimensionality, motivated by the classical fact that finite-area boundaries admit finitely many modes. The result $\varepsilon = 2l_p$ is a *consequence* of self-consistency (§6). Holographic entropy bounds [27] provide independent, non-quantum motivation.

### 9.4 Vacuum Energy: Relative Effects and the Higgs Potential

**Relative effects.** Casimir forces and Lamb shifts are predictions *within* the emergent QFT — relative effects depending on energy differences between configurations. The framework denies that the *absolute* zero-point sum gravitates, because gravity operates at the logically prior classical level (§7.2).

**The Higgs potential.** The strongest CC objection is not the zero-point sum but the electroweak Higgs potential: symmetry breaking shifts $V(\phi)$ by $\sim (200\,\text{GeV})^4$, exceeding the observed $\Lambda$ by $\sim 55$ orders of magnitude. The framework's response follows from its ontological ordering and the structural/volumetric distinction of §5.2, applied as a precise principle:

*What gravitates:* Relative energy differences between configurations of the emergent fields. An electron at rest vs. no electron differs by $m_e c^2$ in the classical substratum — there is a classical microstate difference corresponding to this energy difference. Relative differences appear in the classical stress-energy tensor and gravitate. Casimir forces, Lamb shifts, and particle masses all fall in this category.

*What does not gravitate:* Absolute energy levels assigned to configurations by the emergent description. The Higgs vacuum energy shift $V(\phi_{\text{min}})$ is the energy the emergent QFT assigns to its ground state — the configuration obtained after symmetry breaking. But the "ground state" in the emergent description corresponds to a class of classical microstates whose energy in the classical substratum is $\rho \sim H^2/G$, not $\rho \sim (200\,\text{GeV})^4$. The shift is a property of how the emergent description organizes the microstates (the correspondence), not a property of the microstates themselves (the classical dynamics).

The principle is uniform: the zero-point sum, the Higgs vacuum energy, and the QCD condensate energy are all absolute properties of the emergent ground state. The dissolution applies to each for the same reason — gravity operates at the classical level (§7.2), where none of these quantities appear.

**Why QCD binding energy gravitates but the quantum vacuum does not.** The proton mass is ~99% QCD binding energy — a purely quantum effect. If gravity couples to the classical substratum, how does it "know" about masses generated by emergent quantum dynamics? The answer is that QCD binding energy and vacuum zero-point energy occupy different categories in the structural/volumetric distinction of §5.2. Relative energies within the emergent QFT — energy differences between configurations — correspond to differences in the coupling structure of $\varphi$, which the Jacobson derivation (Fundamental, §5) reads as curvature. A proton vs. three free quarks corresponds to two distinct classes of classical microstates with different energies in the classical substratum; the binding energy $\sim 938$ MeV is a *relative* quantity that appears in $H_{\text{tot}}$ and gravitates. The absolute baseline — the zero-point energy summed over all modes — corresponds to the total information capacity of the hidden sector ($S_{\text{dS}}$), which is a property of the partition geometry, not of the dynamics, and therefore does not source curvature.

### 9.5 Relation to Prior Work

**'t Hooft [1]:** Differs in mechanism (epistemic trace-out vs. information loss), generality (any system satisfying axioms vs. particular rules), and Bell placement (outcome independence violation vs. superdeterminism). **QBism/relational QM:** Share observer-relative epistemic states; this framework provides a structural *why* and quantitative predictions. **Jacobson [16]:** Derives gravity from thermodynamics; this framework derives QM from causal structure — complementary, with mutual consistency as a check.

**Danielson-Satishchandran-Wald (DSW) horizon decoherence [38, 39].** DSW proved within standard QFT that any Killing horizon imparts a fundamental rate of decoherence on nearby quantum superpositions: the horizon registers the long-range field of the superposed body via soft gravitons/photons, destroying coherence at a rate determined by the horizon geometry. This is precisely the framework's partition mechanism described in QFT language — the horizon is the causal boundary, information leaks through it, and the exterior state decoheres. Three specific features match: (i) the decoherence rate depends on horizon geometry (partition-relativity); (ii) decoherence vanishes for extremal black holes where the coupling to the interior is screened (C1 failure); (iii) the process is non-Markovian near the horizon, with information backflow from the interior [40]. The DSW program derives these results within the emergent QFT; the present framework explains *why* horizons produce decoherence — because the trace-out across a causal partition is the mechanism that generates quantum mechanics itself.

**AdS/CFT and the geometry-entanglement connection.** The Ryu-Takayanagi formula, Van Raamsdonk's disconnection argument, ER=EPR, and "it from qubit" programs all suggest entanglement is prior to geometry. The framework offers a uniform alternative reading: tracing out across a geometric boundary produces entanglement entropy proportional to boundary area ($A/\varepsilon^2$ modes), so each of these results is equally consistent with geometry assembling entanglement rather than the reverse. For Ryu-Takayanagi specifically, the proportionality constant must follow from the partition structure — and it does: §6 derives the $1/4$ factor. In the holographic context, the boundary CFT observer is *external* to the bulk, immune to the inferential limits of embedded observers [19]; the framework does not claim to reproduce holographic results in that setting.

The point of contact is empirical. Entanglement-first programs predict spacetime breakdown at low entanglement or high energy. This framework predicts QM breakdown near $\varepsilon = 2\,l_p$ while the geometric substratum persists. The geometry-first ordering produces six independent concordances with observation (§7.2); entanglement-first orderings inherit the zero-point sum as a gravitational source and have no natural account of the dark sector.

Witten's Type II algebra program achieves finite entropy without finite-dimensional Hilbert spaces; this is compatible, since the framework's predictions depend on finite entropy (the physical content of Axiom 2), not on dimensional finiteness per se.

### 9.6 Assumptions, Limitations, and Falsifiability

**The theorem** requires Axiom 2 (independent in Part I; consequence of geometry in Part II), the stochastic-quantum bridge (§3.1 and Appendix A; established by two independent routes), and genericity conditions (non-degenerate spectrum, non-vanishing overlaps), which hold for all but a measure-zero set. The P-indivisibility proof uses finiteness via the recurrence argument ($\varphi^N = \mathrm{id}$). The deep-sector cardinality corollary (§5.2) establishes that only $\mathscr{C}_V$ and $\mathscr{C}_B$ need be finite — both guaranteed by holographic entropy bounds [27] independently of the de Sitter finite-dimensionality conjecture — while the deep sector $\mathscr{C}_D$ may be infinite. The accessible-timescale backflow lemma (§2.3) provides a second route to P-indivisibility that is independent of $|\mathscr{C}_H|$. The characterization theorem becomes an equivalence on observable timescales ($T_{\mathrm{obs}} \ll \tau_B \sim 10^{17}$ s) — physically indistinguishable from a timeless identity for all experiments within the age of the universe.

**The sharp partition and constraint structure.** Axiom 3's product decomposition $\Gamma = \Gamma_V \times \Gamma_H$ is the kinematic phase space. In GR, the Hamiltonian and momentum constraints restrict the physical phase space to a submanifold $\Gamma_{\mathrm{phys}} \subset \Gamma_V \times \Gamma_H$ on which interior and exterior data are correlated. P-indivisibility survives on a constraint surface because restoring P-divisibility would require decoupling the sectors entirely, violating the constraints; the constraint surface thus enforces (C1) non-perturbatively. For systems other than the cosmological horizon, the fidelity of the product approximation determines the fidelity of the emergent quantum description.

**Planck-scale ordering.** The classical-prior ontology may break down at $l_p$, where "geometric" and

"quantum" lose operational distinction. If a deeper theory unifies both, this framework describes the effective macroscopic regime.

**Falsifiability.** The *theorem* would be falsified by a failure of both the stochastic-quantum correspondence and the Stinespring construction for the class of processes generated here — a possibility excluded by the independent proofs in §3.1 and Appendix A. The *cosmological application* would be falsified by definitive absence of dark energy evolution or GW echoes at the predicted timescale. The *dark-sector concordance* (§8.3) would be falsified by detection of dark matter particles accounting for the full structured dark sector, or by evidence that the dark sector's gravitational effects are unrelated to the cosmological boundary geometry.

**Open problems: nested and time-dependent partitions.** The derivation chain assumes a single partition into visible and hidden sectors. In reality, multiple causal boundaries coexist — most naturally, a black hole horizon inside the cosmological horizon — creating nested partitions with distinct geometries. Three layers of the problem can be identified.

*(i) Consistency of nested trace-outs.* Let $V \subset W \subset S$ be nested visible sectors (e.g., $V$ is the region between the black hole and cosmological horizons, $W$ is the cosmological interior). The cosmological trace-out $\mathrm{Tr}_{S\setminus W}$ produces QM on $W$; a subsequent trace-out $\mathrm{Tr}_{W\setminus V}$ over the black hole interior produces a further-reduced description on $V$. The question is whether $\mathrm{Tr}_{S\setminus W} \circ \mathrm{Tr}_{W\setminus V} = \mathrm{Tr}_{S\setminus V}$. For standard partial traces on tensor products this is trivially true, and the spatial product structure of $\mathscr{C}_V$ (§7.1) together with the locality of the classical Hamiltonian ensures that the emergent Hilbert space inherits a compatible tensor product factorization at each level. The associativity of nested trace-outs is therefore expected to hold, but a rigorous proof for the specific class of P-indivisible processes generated here — where the product structure is emergent rather than postulated — remains open. What the framework does predict: both trace-outs yield the same $\hbar$, since $\hbar = c^3\varepsilon^2/(4G)$ depends only on local boundary quantities ($c$, $G$, $\varepsilon$), not on which horizon defines the partition (§5.2, Steps 2–3).

*(ii) The entropy budget and the generalized second law.* The Bekenstein-Hawking entropy $S_{\mathrm{dS}} = A_{\mathrm{dS}}/(4l_p^2)$ is the information compression ratio of the cosmological trace-out. For a black hole with entropy $S_{\mathrm{BH}} = A_{\mathrm{BH}}/(4l_p^2)$, the framework interprets $S_{\mathrm{BH}}$ as the compression ratio of the second (black hole) trace-out. The generalized second law — that $S_{\mathrm{dS}} + S_{\mathrm{BH}} + S_{\mathrm{matter}}$ does not decrease — should emerge as a consistency condition on nested partitions: any process that decreases one boundary's area while increasing accessible information must compensate via the other boundary or the matter sector. Deriving this from the bijection structure of $\varphi$ would provide a strong independent check on the framework.

*(iii) Time-dependent partitions and the black hole information paradox.* An evaporating black hole has a shrinking partition boundary: degrees of freedom transition from hidden to visible as the horizon area decreases. In the fundamental description $(S, \varphi)$, the evolution is always bijective — information is never lost. The apparent information loss in Hawking's calculation is an artifact of treating the emergent QFT's trace-out as if the partition were static. As the black hole evaporates, the partition moves through the state space, and the emergent QM description must be continuously updated. The Page curve — the entropy of Hawking radiation as a function of time — should be derivable from the time-dependent partition geometry: as $A_{\mathrm{BH}}$ shrinks, $S_{\mathrm{BH}}$ decreases, and the mutual information between the radiation and the remaining black hole interior increases. The framework's prediction is definite: the Page curve turns over (unitarity is preserved), because the total evolution is bijective. The quantitative derivation — the Page curve's functional form from the combinatorics of time-dependent trace-outs on a finite coupling graph — is the central open problem.

These three layers — associativity, the generalized second law, and the emergent Page curve — define a research program for nested and evolving partitions. §8.2 treats GW echoes as a specific case; the general theory requires further development. Laboratory tests may be possible in analogue gravity systems where the hidden sector capacity is tunable.

## 10. CONCLUSION

**The general theorem (Part I).** Under four axioms and conditions (C1)–(C3), the P-indivisibility of reduced dynamics is proved: any bijective dynamics on a finite system with non-trivial coupling necessarily produces P-indivisible stochastic dynamics. By the stochastic-quantum correspondence, the observer's description is necessarily quantum mechanics. Continuous-time transition data resolves all gauge freedom. The Schrödinger equation, Born rule, and Bell violations are structural consequences. The characterization theorem establishes that the conditions are necessary: QM and embedded observation under (C1)–(C3) are equivalent.

**The cosmological application (Part II).** The cosmological horizon provides a realization where the sharp-partition approximation is exact and all conditions hold. The theorem yields: (a) $\hbar = c^3\varepsilon^2/(4G)$ with $\varepsilon = 2\,l_p$ and the Bekenstein-Hawking formula as consequences; (b) dissolution of the CC problem — the $10^{122}$ discrepancy is $S_{\mathrm{dS}}$, the compression ratio of the observer's quantum description; (c) falsifiable predictions including RVM dark energy with $\nu_{\mathrm{OI}} \approx 2.45 \times 10^{-3}$ and gravitational wave echoes; and (d) an automatic dark-sector corollary — the same trace-out renders ~95% of the universe's gravitational budget invisible to the emergent QFT, matching the observed composition. The $10^{122}$ information compression ratio and the ~95% gravitational occlusion fraction are two aspects of a single phenomenon: the cost of observing the universe from within.

The apparent conflict between quantum mechanics and general relativity, the $10^{122}$ vacuum energy discrepancy, and the dark sector are three faces of the same fact: the information-theoretic cost of embedded observation.

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## ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

During the preparation of this work, the author used Claude Opus 4.6 (Anthropic) and Gemini 3.1 Pro (Google) to assist in drafting, refining argumentation, and verifying bibliographic details. The author reviewed and edited all content and takes full responsibility for the publication.


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## APPENDIX A: INDEPENDENT DERIVATION VIA STINESPRING DILATION

This appendix derives the emergent quantum description using only Stinespring's dilation theorem [32] and standard properties of the partial trace [33], without invoking the stochastic-quantum correspondence [10, 11]. The two routes are logically independent; either alone suffices.

### A.1 Setup

The finite configuration spaces $\mathscr{C}_V = \{x_1, \ldots, x_n\}$ and $\mathscr{C}_H = \{h_1, \ldots, h_m\}$ (Axiom 2) embed into Hilbert spaces $\mathscr{H}_V = \mathbb{C}^n$ and $\mathscr{H}_H = \mathbb{C}^m$ via $|i\rangle \leftrightarrow x_i$ and $|k\rangle \leftrightarrow h_k$. This introduces no quantum postulates: it is the canonical identification of probability distributions on a finite set with diagonal density matrices.

### A.2 Permutation Unitarity

**Lemma A.1.** *Any bijection $\varphi : \mathscr{C}_V \times \mathscr{C}_H \to \mathscr{C}_V \times \mathscr{C}_H$ defines a unitary $U_\varphi$ on $\mathscr{H} = \mathscr{H}_V \otimes \mathscr{H}_H$.*

*Proof.* Define $U_\varphi|i,k\rangle = |\varphi(x_i,h_k)\rangle$. Since $\varphi$ is a bijection, $U_\varphi$ permutes the orthonormal basis, hence is unitary. □

For continuous-time dynamics $\varphi_t$, Stone's theorem on $\mathscr{H}$ yields $U_t = e^{-i\hat{H}t}$ for Hermitian $\hat{H}$.

### A.3 The Quantum Channel

The observer's ignorance of the hidden sector (Axioms 3–4) corresponds to $\rho_H = I_m/m$. The visible-sector quantum channel is

$$\Phi(\rho_V) = \mathrm{Tr}_H\left[U_\varphi\left(\rho_V \otimes \rho_H\right)U_\varphi^\dagger\right]$$

This is CPTP by a standard result [33, Theorem 8.1], with Kraus representation $\Phi(\rho_V) = \sum_{k,l} K_{kl}\,\rho_V\,K_{kl}^\dagger$ where $K_{kl} = m^{-1/2}\langle l|U_\varphi|k\rangle_H$. The triple $(\mathscr{H}_H, U_\varphi, \rho_H)$ is the Stinespring dilation [32] of $\Phi$.

### A.4 Born Rule Recovery

**Theorem A.2.** *The classical transition probabilities $T_{ij}$ (§1.4) equal the Born-rule probabilities of $\Phi$.*

*Proof.* $P(j|i) = \langle j|\Phi(|i\rangle\langle i|)|j\rangle = m^{-1}\sum_{k,l}|\langle j,l|U_\varphi|i,k\rangle|^2$. Since $U_\varphi$ is a permutation, $\langle j,l|U_\varphi|i,k\rangle = \delta_{(j,l),\varphi(i,k)}$. Thus $P(j|i) = m^{-1}\sum_k \delta_{j,\pi_V(\varphi(x_i,h_k))} = T_{ij}$. □

### A.5 Emergent Coherence

**Theorem A.3.** *If $T$ is not a permutation matrix (condition (C1)), then $\Phi$ generates genuine quantum coherence: it is not entanglement-breaking.*

*Proof.* If $T$ is not a permutation, some initial state $|i\rangle$ maps to at least two distinct outputs, so $\Phi(|i\rangle\langle i|)$ has rank $\geq 2$. By linearity, $\Phi$ maps some off-diagonal input $|i\rangle\langle j|$ to a non-zero operator, precluding the measure-and-prepare form of entanglement-breaking channels. □

### A.6 CP-Indivisibility

**Theorem A.4.** *The P-indivisibility of §2.3 implies CP-indivisibility of $\{\Phi_t\}$: there exist $t_2 > t_1 > 0$ with no CPTP map $\Lambda$ satisfying $\Phi_{t_2} = \Lambda \circ \Phi_{t_1}$.*

*Proof.* CP-divisibility restricted to diagonal inputs reduces to P-divisibility. The contrapositive gives the result. □

By the Breuer-Laine-Piilo criterion [4, 6], CP-indivisibility implies non-monotonic trace distance (information backflow) — the quantum signature of non-Markovianity.

### A.7 Approximate Unitarity

On observable timescales $t \ll \tau_B$, the hidden-sector state is approximately frozen (conditions (C2)–(C3)). The channel generator decomposes as $d\Phi_t/dt|_{t=0}(\rho_V) = -i[\hat{H}_{\mathrm{eff}}, \rho_V] + \mathscr{D}(\rho_V)$ with $\mathscr{D} \sim \mathscr{O}(\tau_S/\tau_B)$. The leading-order dynamics is the Schrödinger equation. The phase-locking lemma (§3.1) and D-gauge theorem (§5.3) then determine $\hat{H}_{\mathrm{eff}}$ uniquely from continuous-time transition data.

### A.8 Comparison of Routes

| | Barandes route (§3.1) | Stinespring route (this appendix) |
|---|---|---|
| Input | P-indivisible process on $\mathscr{C}_V$ | Bijection on $\mathscr{C}_V \times \mathscr{C}_H$ + marginalization |
| Bridge | Stochastic-quantum correspondence [10, 11] | Stinespring dilation [32] + partial trace [33] |
| Output | Unitary with $T_{ij} = \|U_{ij}\|^2$ | CPTP channel with $T_{ij} = \langle j\|\Phi(\|i\rangle\langle i\|)\|j\rangle$ |
| Born rule | Equilibrium of indivisible process | Partial trace structure (Theorem A.2) |
| Scope | Any P-indivisible process | Processes from marginalized bijections |

The Barandes route is more general (any P-indivisible process); the Stinespring route requires only textbook results [32, 33] and delivers additional structure: the tensor product $\mathscr{H}_V \otimes \mathscr{H}_H$, genuine quantum coherence (Theorem A.3), CP-indivisibility (Theorem A.4), and approximate unitarity with $\mathscr{D} \sim \mathscr{O}(\tau_S/\tau_B) \sim 10^{-32}$ (§A.7). The two routes agree on all observables — both produce the same $T_{ij}(t)$ — establishing that the emergence of QM is robust and overdetermined. The Barandes route powers (ii) $\implies$ (i) in the characterization theorem; the Stinespring route supplies (iii) $\implies$ (i) independently.